enemy engaged till our main force was able to cross the obstacle upstream and then attack them from the rear.

In the meanwhile, the weather suddenly deteriorated, and it started raining heavily. Visibility dropped to a few metres. We were operating at an altitude of over 10,000 feet, and within a few minutes we were drenched to the bone. In Arunachal Pradesh, the annual rainfall in places is perhaps even more than in Cherrapunji, which used to be considered as the rainiest place on earth. But, on this day, it appeared to be worse, something like a cloudburst. The nullah became a raging torrent and impossible to cross, something highly unusual and unexpected during May. I asked Major M.N.S. Thampi, the leading sub-unit commander, to do whatever was required to be done, but he said that even huge pine trees that they had attempted to place across the stream were being washed away like straws with the force and velocity of the water. We decided to wait for the rain to stop but the intensity of the rain increased further.

By now my brigade commander was quite restless. Even though I had kept him informed of the events as they were unfolding, he could not fully comprehend the situation we were facing, though he was a hardcore infantryman himself. He began to push me harder and harder. The pressure building up in our brigade HQ was becoming palpable. However, I did not pass on this pressure to my subordinates, and tried to remain cool. I was sure my company commanders were doing their best.

Around 3 a.m., it was still dark and raining when Brigadier Airy came on the air again. I told him the situation had only become worse.

'JJ, dammit, have you chickened out? I thought you were made of sterner stuff,' said the agitated brigadier.

'No, sir. But there is no way anyone can get across this nullah. Yet my boys haven't given up and are still trying,' was my response.

'That does not impress me, JJ. The fact is that your forces have been stuck up at the same place for half the night, and it seems to me that not enough is being done,' shouted Brigadier Airy.